Part 2: How Claude works

Claude Certified Associate Foundations course · cheat sheet

2.0 Part 2: How Claude works, for people who don't code

F1 What a language model really does

Claude predicts what fits next. That makes it fluent, and it means fluent and true are two separate things you have to check.
Avoid: 1. treating a confident tone as proof · 2. thinking it looks facts up in a database

F2 Tokens and the context window

Claude can only use what's in its context window. Put the right things on the desk once, and keep unrelated work in a separate chat.
Avoid: 1. pasting the same document again and again · 2. one chat for every topic, all week

F3 Each chat starts blank, and what changes that

New chats start blank. Projects, memory and chat search carry context forward, and incognito keeps it out.
Avoid: 1. expecting a new chat to know yesterday's work · 2. mixing unrelated clients in one project

F4 Why Claude sometimes makes things up

Precise details are the red flags. Grounding helps, but only checking against a real source counts as verification.
Avoid: 1. checking only for wild inventions · 2. asking Claude 'are you sure?' and accepting yes

F5 What Claude can know, and what it can't

Claude knows what it learned, finds what it can search, and sees your private data only when you share it or connect an app.
Avoid: 1. asking about your own systems with nothing shared · 2. forgetting a connector is on

F6 The Claude map: choosing the right feature

Match the feature to the task. Chat for quick, Projects for ongoing, artifacts for things you keep, code for exact numbers, search for what's new.
Avoid: 1. using Research for a simple lookup · 2. doing maths in plain chat · 3. re-pasting background instead of using a project

F7 The model family: Haiku, Sonnet and Opus

Haiku for fast and simple, Sonnet for most work, Opus for the hardest. Match the model to the task's stakes and volume.
Avoid: 1. always picking the biggest model · 2. picking the smallest for high-stakes work

F8 Where your data goes

Know your training setting, know what incognito does and doesn't do, and strip personal details before they go in.
Avoid: 1. thinking 'tell Claude not to keep it' protects data · 2. thinking incognito makes anything safe to share